



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Course Report: Master's Thesis in Political Science (SK2532), fall 2021 and spring 2022

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The course Master's Thesis is an in-depth course in Political Science. The course is compulsory within the Political Science Master's Programme. The thesis is the degree project for a Master's degree in Political Science. The course is placed at the spring semester the final year of the Master's programme, but it is possible for students to instead write their thesis during the fall and present it in January. This report covers the fall semester 2021 and the spring semester 2022. During the course the students write an independent, in-depth scientific thesis and defend it orally at a mandatory seminar. The teaching on the course differs from many other courses in the sense that most of the work is done independently by the student. The teaching mainly comes in the form of individual supervision. Before the course starts, the students are in contact with the coordinator for the Master's thesis course, who helps students to find a suitable supervisor. In addition to the individual supervision, there were two voluntary feedback seminars during the spring semester 2022, where students got feedback on their work so far from the course coordinator as well as from other students. The course ends with mandatory thesis seminars, where the students present their thesis and discuss another student's thesis.

During fall 2021/spring 2022, 59 students were registered on the course. Of these, 33 had completed the course by September 2022. 19 students received the grade Pass (G) and 14 students Pass with Distinction (VG).

The students were asked to fill in the course evaluation after the course was completed. Out of 63 students who received the evaluation survey, 16 students responded (25%).¹ The results for the survey are reported below alongside the results from spring semesters 2020 and 2021. There were no major changes to the course compared to previous years, apart from a thorough revision of the grading criteria to make them clearer and better reflect the factors that are taken into account in the grading process (this affected students during the spring semester). Most students assess the course as Very good (37,5%) or Rather good (50%) which is in line with previous years.

For coming semesters, we will move one of the feedback seminars from the spring semester to the fall before the course starts. The reasons are that earlier feedback on research ideas would likely give the students more of a head start, and that the second feedback seminar (in March) tends to be not very well attended. The feedback seminar during the fall will be on Zoom, since many of the students do their internships at this point in their studies.

¹ The survey was sent to all students who had access to the Canvas page, which was a few more than those registered on the course. The response rate among the 59 students who were actually registered is therefore slightly higher, 27%.

Survey responses:

Overall, how would you assess the course?	2020	2021	2022
Very good	3 (17,6%)	3 (37,5%)	6 (37,5%)
Rather good	13 (76,5%)	4 (50,0%)	8 (50,0%)
Neither good nor bad	1 (5,9%)	0 (0,0%)	1 (6,2%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)	1 (6,2%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)	1 (12,5%)	0 (0,0%)
Total	17 (100,0%)	8 (100,0%)	16 (100,0%)

Overall, how would you assess the supervision of the thesis?	2020	2021	2022
Very good	4 (23,5%)	3 (37,5%)	8 (50,0%)
Rather good	9 (52,9%)	4 (50,0%)	5 (31,2%)
Neither good nor bad	3 (17,6%)	0 (0,0%)	1 (6,2%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)	2 (12,5%)
Very bad	1 (5,9%)	1 (12,5%)	0 (0,0%)
Total	17 (100,0%)	8 (100,0%)	16 (100,0%)

Overall, how would you assess the examination seminars? (Note: in 2020 and 2021 the question was "Overall, how would you assess the seminars?")	2020	2021	2022
Very good	6 (35,3%)	1 (12,5%)	3 (18,8%)
Rather good	4 (23,5%)	4 (50,0%)	8 (50,0%)
Neither good nor bad	7 (41,2%)	2 (25,0%)	3 (18,8%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)	2 (12,5%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)	1 (12,5%)	0 (0,0%)
Total	17 (100,0%)	8 (100,0%)	16 (100,0%)

How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?	2020	2021	2022
Very good	6 (35,3%)	4 (50,0%)	7 (43,8%)
Rather good	7 (41,2%)	3 (37,5%)	3 (18,8%)
Neither good nor bad	3 (17,6%)	0 (0,0%)	5 (31,2%)
Rather bad	1 (5,9%)	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)	1 (12,5%)	1 (6,2%)
Total	17 (100,0%)	8 (100,0%)	16 (100,0%)

What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	2020	2021	2022
Much too demanding	0 (0,0%)	1 (12,5%)	0 (0,0%)
Somewhat too demanding	2 (11,8%)	0 (0,0%)	2 (12,5%)
OK	12 (70,6%)	5 (62,5%)	12 (75,0%)
Not that demanding	3 (17,6%)	2 (25,0%)	2 (12,5%)
Not at all demanding	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)
Total	17 (100,0%)	8 (100,0%)	16 (100,0%)

On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?	2020	2021	2022
Less than 10 hours	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)
11-20 hours	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)	1 (6,2%)
21-30 hours	4 (23,5%)	2 (25,0%)	5 (31,2%)
31-40 hours	8 (47,1%)	5 (62,5%)	6 (37,5%)
More than 40 hours	5 (29,4%)	1 (12,5%)	4 (25,0%)
Total	17 (100,0%)	8 (100,0%)	16 (100,0%)

In general, how do you think that the distance teaching worked during the course?	2020	2021	2022
Very good	3 (17,6%)	2 (25,0%)	8 (50,0%)
Quite good	10 (58,8%)	4 (50,0%)	7 (43,8%)
Neither good nor bad	4 (23,5%)	1 (12,5%)	0 (0,0%)
Quite bad	0 (0,0%)	0 (0,0%)	1 (6,2%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)	1 (12,5%)	0 (0,0%)
Total	17 (100,0%)	8 (100,0%)	16 (100,0%)

Apart from the evaluation questions, the survey included questions about which methods course the student had taken, with an open-ended follow-up question ("What of the things that you learnt during the methods course have been especially helpful while writing your thesis? And was there something you missed from the methods course that you now realize would have been helpful while writing your thesis?").

Of the students that responded to the survey, 6 had taken the course Applied statistical analysis (SF2321). The answers to the open-ended question show that these students found the course very

helpful during the work with the thesis, with specific mentions of time series analysis and regression diagnostics. It is also mentioned that the course helped in choosing the most suitable statistical method for their research question.

5 of the respondents had taken the course Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists (SF2324). What they learned about OLS regression is mentioned as valuable during the thesis work.

The course Applied Qualitative Research Methods (SF2322) had been taken by two of the responding students. Answers to the follow-up indicate that what they learned about interviews on the course, both theoretically and practically, was helpful in the thesis writing process.

7 of the respondents had taken the course Applied Qualitative Research Methods, problems and design (SF2323). While most of these did not provide a response to the open-ended question, the response that is there is more critical. The view is that the course demands too little of the students for a master's level course, and that they did not learn anything new.